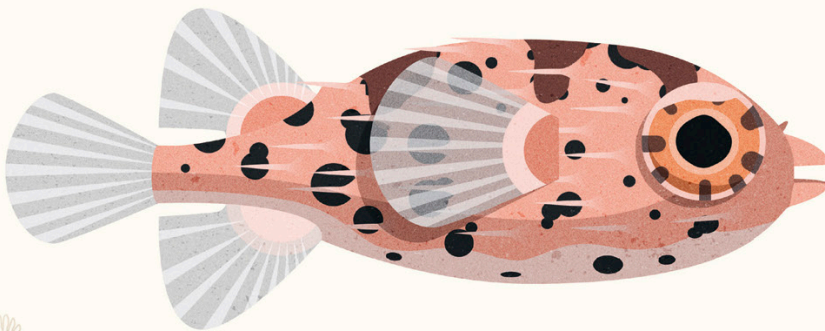


*Dolphins tease porcupine fish to
make them inflate, seemingly
just for fun.*

Porcupine fish

One minute, it's a small and ordinary-looking fish. Then — whoosh — it becomes a spiky beachball! When a porcupine fish senses danger, it gulps water into its stomach, which swells up to 100 times its usual size. The prickly fish would be a painful mouthful for a hungry shark or turtle, so the predator swims off to find an easier meal. Once safe, the porcupine fish deflates like a party balloon — in fact, these animals are also sometimes called balloonfish.

Inflating uses up valuable energy, so porcupine fish hide in the day, and come out at night. They comb coral reefs for spiky sea urchins and crunchy crabs to eat. A strong beak helps crush tough foods.



Longspine porcupine fish,
Worldwide tropical oceans